

Critical Reflection on Phenomenology as of Wednesday, 31st August 2022
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Phenomenology is by far my most favoured interest in this course, as I believe it has the most to offer the discipline in the form of humanistic design potential. It is also the category in which I am most well-versed. I truly agree that a building is to be more than seen and observed, rather it is much more intuitive and natural to be felt and engaged with. This being said, I am still (and probably always will be) confused as to how exactly this is achieved.

It may always be impossible to derive a set of guiding principles to design something that caters to all individual perception - this is in its own way a type of continuity.

In its own way, this is even more exciting, as the infinite possibilities offer much to experiment with and learn from with each design. These findings, though, can often only be learned much later in retrospect - after the effects of the building have truly been experienced by the end user. It is true that the ideology lacks theoretical foundation in an objective regard, but that is the point exactly - lived experience is that which is subjective and individual, and cannot be compared to an "objective" truth. It is my opinion that the philosophy (when not used to generalise and aim for "universal" experience) supports the idea that there is no Truth, but a series of interpretations of it.

I personally do not see deconstruction as a direct opposite to this statement (and by extension, this interpretation of phenomenology as a whole).

It is easy to see why postmodernism creates a contradiction in itself, and I believe this is a response to how phenomenology is considered and applied. I do not at all see it as a theory on its own, as it lacks a critical approach.

Kenneth Frampton best articulates an approach embedded with phenomenological thought: critical regionalism is that which considers itself a contextually-relevant engagement of the senses, not just a blind sensual experience derived from past knowledge.

The problem with the latter is likely the epistemological impact of eurocentric architecture and the tendency to perpetuate a relationship with the built form that revolves around the sensory experiences of the heterosexual white man. The ideologies of phenomenology can be misused in this regard. However, when taken to task like in the works of Miriam Kamara, David Adjaye, and Sumayya Vally.

Phenomenology as a tool in the hands of the norm is different from being a tool in the hands of the oppressed that seek expression.

Creating from a sense of "home" is by default different from the sterile enclosure of the Built Form. The instinct and intuition of the subaltern peoples will by nature be provocative, and hence be a part of deconstruction as a philosophy of creating new positions that challenge binaries.

It is exciting to see, and it is my personal position to use deconstruction as a philosophy and phenomenology as a tool to execute it.